

The poor little rich boy

I'M OLD ENOUGH TO HAVE GROWN UP READING COMIC BOOKS (AND BOOKS) MY ENTIRE CHILDHOOD. Everything from Archie and his friends, to the war propaganda Com-mando Comics that I loved at the time, it was all grabbed, read, re-read and read once more, cover-to-cover.

Growing up relatively poor in New Delhi, the son of a couple of underpaid teachers, meant that I was used to being told "No" when I wanted something. And I was brought up well enough to not ask for too much, too often, and certainly never in front of others, in order to spare my parents the embarrassment of admitting that so much was out of their economic reach.

The big advantage to being brought up by teachers was that reading was always encouraged. The one thing money was always kept aside for was an all-you-can-read subscription to the local library. And read everything, I did. Apart from the Mills and Boon section of the library, which I avoided like the plague, everything else was fair game.

My favourite comic for a while, understandably in retrospect, was the Richie Rich series. I don't know what drew me to it, perhaps being the polar opposite of the world's richest boy made the comic series so addictive.

For those unfamiliar with the comic, it was designed to show all of us poor people in the world that money was not everything. The world's richest boy had more money than he knew what to do with, but he was lonely, had few friends, and was always fighting off people looking to steal his dad's money and inventions.

From a more modern lens, it's a tale of how the richest people on earth are all related, and control so much of the power, all the while wowing poorer people with a lifestyle and gadgets those people will never ever be able to afford. A world where whimsical purchases rival the economies of small countries! And yes, though you'd feel sorry for little Richie Rich at times, the comic series did also showcase that most of the other rich people were pretty tone deaf to the needs of regular folk, and in many cases downright disdainful of the poorer classes.

As I grew older, I felt a sense of how hard the comics were trying, and how it was a miracle that they fooled millions of us kids

into empathising with a little rich kid who had everything and more.

This is something that continued into adulthood, and not just for Richie Rich, and not just for me.

Billionaires were pretty much always reviled in all circles. And for a heck of a lot of us at the time, Bill Gates was the billionaire that everyone hated. Why? Who cares? Should we waste time on sympathy for the world's richest man (at the time)? "It's ok, he can wipe away his tears with \$100 bills" was the response thrown out at anyone who dared to stand up for Bill Gates' contribution to software and computers.

For the longest time I thought that Richie Rich would be the only ever billionaire (fictional or real) that many people would love.

Then came Steve Jobs, who was the billionaire that came closest to becoming a tech-messiah, with people hanging on to his every word, fighting with anyone who dared besmirch his name. I thought it was a lot to do with Apple early adopters, who were in essence defending their own purchase, and not Steve Jobs the person.

Never would I imagine, however, that there'd be a billionaire who made products that far fewer people were early adopters of, and yet still be a cult icon.

Yet here we are...

The memes are flying around the internet about Elon Musk buying Twitter. For every person who says something negative, there are more who will attack the naysayers.

Apparently people with over 200 billion dollars don't meet the rules for instant hate that other billionaires just inherit. Gates promised his entire fortune to charitable causes, and that still didn't change people's minds about him!

Even Elon himself is poking fun at Gates on Twitter, and also challenging Vladimir Putin to a physical fight over Ukraine... Elon is a troll, and people love trolls. The fact that he's been competent at building things (or having them built by others) adds on to the cult status he has.

I don't know if Twitter will be better or worse after this, and frankly I don't really care because I'm not an avid user anyway. What I do admire about Elon Musk is his ability to get people to genuinely care for "the poor little rich boy" who can make a 44 billion dollar impulse buy. In 2022, that's truly impressive to me! 



"The world's richest boy had more money than he knew what to do with, but he was lonely, had few friends, and was always fighting off people looking to steal his dad's money"



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